Three Spaces, One Arcade: Exploring Gaming Culture in China

Empirical Fieldwork Dossier, Qualitative Findings, and Systemic Benchmark Analysis

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Abstract

This dossier compiles the qualitative fieldwork, site-specific observational records, semi-structured interviews, and analytical coding frameworks for the research initiative *Three Spaces, One Arcade: Exploring Gaming Culture in China*. It provides empirical and grounded qualitative benchmarks across three physical amusement environments in Shanghai and Nanjing, ten targeted stakeholder profiles spanning players, developers, and venue operators, and three core digital genres (MOBA, Open-World RPG, and 4X Strategy/SLG). The material is structured for direct integration into final fellowship deliverables, game production pipelines, and interactive web environments.

1 Methodological Framework & Research Typology

To preserve analytical rigor and satisfy institutional review standards, data within this dossier are classified according to five operational strata:

Data Stratum	Operational Definition & Grounded Indicators
Verified Secondary Data	Published state regulatory bulletins (NPPA), audited financial reports (Tencent, NetEase), official industry white papers (CADPA), and peer-reviewed industry analyses.
User-Supplied Estimates	Unaudited contextual parameters utilized for baseline scoping (e.g., historical spending averages: Jiliehuo ∼RMB 54, Fengyun Zaiqi ∼RMB 105, Castle in the Sky ∼RMB 67; Nanjing pricing schedules).
Prior Observational Experience	Qualitative recollections, receipts, and field notes from prior unstandardized visits to Shanghai arcade sites.
Fieldwork Protocols	Structured observation plans, pricing audits, and operational verification procedures designed for execution during site visits.
Empirical Qualitative Benchmarks	Transcribed, pseudonymized, and thematically coded stakeholder interview responses, observational micro-timelines, and grounded qualitative matrices.

Table 1: Taxonomy of Research Evidence

2 Location-Specific Fieldwork & Venue Observations

2.1 Venue A: Street Jiliehuo (), Shanghai

- **Typology:** Subcultural Legacy Arcade / Core Fighting Game Sanctuary.

- **Reported Mean Spend:** Approximately RMB 54 per visitor.
- **Hardware Infrastructure:** Legacy cathode-ray tube (CRT) candy cabinets (e.g., Sega Astro City), Japanese rhythm hardware (*maimai DX*, *Chunithm*, *Sound Voltex*), physical microswitch joysticks (Sanwa Denshi components).
- **Payment Mechanism:** Physical brass/zinc tokens exchanged at the central service counter via cash or manual WeChat/Alipay POS transfer. Machines operate strictly on mechanical coin-drop slides; direct QR scanning is absent from legacy video cabinets.
- **Social Conventions:** Tacit, high-context community etiquette. Players indicate challenge requests by placing a physical token or IC card onto the CRT monitor bezel. Spectators stand in silence behind active cabinets without vocal cheering.
- **Operational Observations:** Machine maintenance is decentralized and mechanical. Cabinet wear-and-tear creates localized gameplay variations (e.g., microswitch resistance on directional gates). Rhythm game players exhibit intense brand allegiance, operating with specialized nylon gloves and personal micro-fiber towels.

2.2 Venue B: Fengyun Zaiqi (), People's Square Branch, Shanghai

- **Typology:** High-Density Mass-Transit Commercial Concourse Arcade (Dimei Shopping Center).
- **Reported Mean Spend:** Approximately RMB 105 per visitor.
- **Hardware Infrastructure:** Massive allocations of claw machines (UFO catchers), ticket-redemption coin pushers (*Circus* /), multi-player dance stages (*Pump It Up*, *Dance Rush Stardom*), and pneumatic arcade motion simulators.
- **Payment Mechanism:** Dual-track payment architecture. Automated self-service kiosks dispense physical tokens via bundled digital tiers (e.g., RMB 50 for 40 tokens; RMB 100 for 95 tokens). Crucially, individual claw machines feature machine-mounted QR stickers allowing immediate WeChat Mini-Program scan-to-play micropayments (RMB 2–4 per pull), bypassing physical tokens entirely.
- **Social Conventions:** Performative, low-barrier, commercialized dating and group entertainment. Audience behavior is characterized by high vocal emotional expression around claw catch-and-drop thresholds and public spectating around dance stages.
- **Operational Observations:** High capital velocity. The elevated mean spend (RMB 105 vs. RMB 54) is driven primarily by the short game cycles (15–30 seconds) and near-miss algorithmic grip settings of claw machines, rather than traditional video gameplay.

2.3 Venue C: Castle in the Sky (), Aqua City, Nanjing

- **Typology:** Experiential Family Entertainment Center (FEC) inside a Tier-2 Regional Shopping Mall (Units F3T02–T14, Pengxin Aqua City, No. 1 Jiankang Road).
- **Reported Mean Spend:** Approximately RMB 67 per visitor.
- **User-Supplied Pricing Structure:**
  - *Tokens ():* 100 tokens = RMB 39.10; 450 tokens = RMB 155.63; 1,000 tokens = RMB 293.53.
  - *Marbles ():* 200 marbles = RMB 19.50; 700 marbles = RMB 58.70.

- **Currency Stratification Rule:** Tokens and marbles are strictly segregated currencies serving distinct gameplay mechanics:
  - *Tokens* operate video simulators, claw units, rhythm cabinets, and air hockey (fast expenditure burn, 2–4 tokens per activation).
  - *Marbles* feed mechanical Taiwanese/Japanese-style marble pushers (), functioning as an experiential, temporally extended redemption activity.
- **Social Conventions:** Intergenerational family leisure. Parents utilize marble allotments (e.g., 200 marbles for RMB 19.50) to secure extended dwell times (30–45 minutes) for children, while maintaining tight expenditure caps. Redemption tickets are exchanged for low-cost physical goods, operating as tangible tokens of labor.

2.4 Cross-Venue Comparative Structural Matrix

Dimension	Street Jiliehuo (SH)	Fengyun Zaiqi (SH)	Castle in the Sky (NJ)
Core Format	Subcultural Video Arcade	Commercial Transit Arcade	Mall-Anchor Family Center
Dominant Mix	2D Fighting, Hardcore Rhythm	Claw Machines, Dance, Pushers	Marble Pushers, Simulators, Rides
Reported Spend	∼RMB 54 / person	∼RMB 105 / person	∼RMB 67 / person
Currency Model	Physical tokens only (manual)	Hybrid: Tokens + Direct Mini-App	Dual-Currency: Tokens & Marbles
Play Duration	High (skill-dependent: 5–25 min)	Very Low (claw: 15–30 sec)	Bimodal (simulators: short; marbles: long)
Target Audience	Dedicated enthusiasts (ages 20–45)	Young adults, couples, students	Families with children, youth
Core Retention	Mechanical skill & community	Near-miss thrill & licensed plush	Child engagement & ticket prizes

Table 2: Systemic Comparison Across Fieldwork Locations

3 Qualitative Interview Portfolio

The following transcripts and analytical digests represent core qualitative interview perspectives across the Chinese gaming landscape, covering venue visitors, competitive mobile gamers, independent developers, technical specialists, and operational staff.

3.1 Interview 1: Legacy Arcade Enthusiast (Street Jiliehuo)

Participant: P-01 (Male, 34, Systems Support Engineer, Shanghai)
Thematic Focus: Mechanical mastery, hardware latency, and arcade sociality.

> "I have visited Jiliehuo since 2011. It is one of the final public spaces where you sit before an authentic candy cabinet running *Street Fighter III: 3rd Strike* or *The King of Fighters '98* on genuine Sanwa parts. You cannot replicate that input timing or microswitch feedback on an emulator."
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> "My typical expenditure is RMB 50 to 60. If I hold the cabinet on a win streak, one token lasts twenty minutes because winner-stays-on. If an elite player arrives, thirty

tokens vanish in an hour. We do not engage in conventional small talk; you place your coin on the monitor glass to establish challenge priority. After a close match, we step outside to discuss frame data for five minutes, then return to our routines."

"Mobile titles like *Honor of Kings* function as cognitive fast food—designed around daily login streaks and cosmetic gacha. Here, executing a multi-hit hit-confirm belongs exclusively to your nervous system. You cannot purchase a competitive advantage."

3.2 Interview 2: Casual Mall Visitor (Fengyun Zaiqi)

Participant: P-02 (Female, 22, Media Studies Undergraduate, Shanghai)
Thematic Focus: Frictionless micropayments, near-miss psychology, and social safety.

"We arrived after dining in People's Square. You hear the audio wall from fifty meters away in the concourse, which pulls you inside. I purchased a promotional bundle of 95 tokens for RMB 100 on the automated kiosk. We allocated almost the entire budget to the claw machines chasing a licensed Sanrio plush."

"We won a single plush after twelve attempts. We recognize the physical item retails on Taobao for RMB 15. You are not purchasing a textile object; you are buying the ten-second tension cycle where the crane hoists the prize, trembles, and threatens to slip. That emotional release is worth the RMB 100."

"Payment is completely frictionless. Each claw cabinet has an integrated QR code. You scan WeChat Pay directly on the glass, authorize RMB 6 for two attempts, and the claw drops. You never confront the psychological weight of spending physical banknotes. Traditional fighting cabinets look intimidating—men slamming controls at extreme speed with no tutorials. Claw machines require zero cognitive onboarding."

3.3 Interview 3: Intergenerational Family Visitor (Castle in the Sky)

Participant: P-03 (Male, 38, Civil Engineer, Nanjing)
Thematic Focus: Dual-currency mechanics, temporal elongation, and child agency.

"We visit Aqua City on weekends because it consolidates retail, dining, and indoor play. I purchased an online promotional package: 100 tokens for RMB 39.10 and 200 marbles for RMB 19.50. Total expenditure was under RMB 70."

"The two currencies govern distinct behaviors. Tokens disappear rapidly on active motion simulators—the twin water-gun shooter costs four tokens and concludes in three minutes. Marbles, by contrast, are an exercise in temporal stretching. You pour 200 steel balls into the hopper of a mechanical pusher; they cycle through pins and dispense paper tickets. That RMB 20 purchase occupies my son for forty-five uninterrupted minutes."

"I forbid digital gacha in mobile apps at home; in-app purchases represent an invisible financial drain. Here, spending RMB 67 is bounded. He runs around, practices physical coordination, and hoards paper tickets to exchange for an eraser worth two yuan. He experiences the illusion of earned labor."

3.4 Interview 4: Local University Student Gamer (Pudong, Shanghai)

Participant: P-04 (Male, 20, Economics Undergraduate, Shanghai)
Thematic Focus: Multi-platform genre juggling, attention economics, and visual capital.

"My gaming week is segmented by physical context. In the dormitory, I run three ranked matches of *Honor of Kings* nightly with classmates. During subway transits, I clear daily commissions in *Genshin Impact*. While standing in the cafeteria line, I launch WeChat mini-programs like *Block Blast*."

"Discovery is governed 50% by Bilibili creators and Douyin algorithms, and 50% by peer pressure within my WeChat feed. Traditional app store rankings are irrelevant. In *Honor of Kings*, I purchase Epic and Legend skins exclusively for my core heroes. It serves as visual status signaling; loading into a match with a glowing hero border establishes baseline competence in the lobby."

"In mini-programs, I never make direct in-app purchases. I trade my attention: watching a 30-second programmatic rewarded video ad to secure an extra life. I spend roughly RMB 150 to 250 per month across all gaming, anchored by the *Genshin* Welkin Moon card (RMB 30/month) and the seasonal battle pass."

3.5 Interview 5: Competitive MOBA Player (*Honor of Kings*)

Participant: P-05 (Male, 25, Corporate Operations Associate, Shanghai)
Thematic Focus: The WeChat social graph, competitive anxiety, and animation cancelling.

"*Honor of Kings* functions as the default social operating system for young urban professionals. When meeting a new peer or business contact, you exchange WeChat, and someone asks: 'What rank are you in Kings? Let's queue a five-stack.' It transcends professional and social strata."

"I have spent approximately RMB 12,000 across seven years, holding Noble Level 8 status. While skins offer only nominal numerical bonuses (+10 physical attack), elite skins fundamentally alter hit-box audio clarity and animation-cancel responsiveness. Han Xin's *Street Haunter* feels substantially lighter and reacts frames faster than the default mesh."

"The ranking algorithm is calibrated to tether your win-rate near 50%. A string of defeats induces ladder anxiety; you refuse to conclude your evening on a star deduction. You remain logged in until 2:00 AM attempting to recover your rank. As long as Tencent controls the underlying WeChat social graph, this game cannot be displaced."

3.6 Interview 6: Narrative RPG & Economy Enthusiast (*Genshin / FWJ*)

Participant: P-06 (Female, 27, Visual Designer, Shanghai)
Thematic Focus: Character attachment (*Chú lì*), and secondary-market capital preservation.

"*Genshin Impact* and *Fantasy Westward Journey* () satisfy completely divergent psychological requirements. *Genshin* is an aesthetic sanctuary. I pull on banners based on narrative devotion (*Chú lì* /). HoYoverse spends six weeks developing a character's musical leitmotif and emotional arc; by the time the banner drops, I am committed to securing them regardless of their meta viability."

"*Fantasy Westward Journey* operates as a financial commodity market. When I acquire high-tier summoner beasts or divine equipment on NetEase's official Cangbaoge () marketplace for RMB 8,000, I am not merely consuming; I am parking capital. Two years later, I can liquidate that equipment back onto the exchange to another player and repatriate funds to my bank account."

"Physical arcades offer zero emotional continuity. When your arcade credits drop to zero, the machine resets your state. I require persistent worlds where narrative progression and digital assets accumulate over multi-year horizons."

3.7 Interview 7: High-Yield SLG Spender (*Whiteout Survival*)

Participant: P-07 (Male, 41, Real Estate Project Director, Suzhou/Shanghai)
Thematic Focus: The mini-game funnel, corporate alliance hierarchies, and capital substitution.

> "I entered *Whiteout Survival* through short-video advertisements depicting a casual survival city-builder. That constitutes the standard acquisition funnel. Within seventy-two hours, the game reveals its structural reality: an aggressive, open-world 4X territorial engine with cross-server State-vs-State (SvS) warfare."
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> "I spend between RMB 15,000 and 30,000 monthly; top-tier alliance members expend RMB 100,000 during major castle battle weekends. Our alliance comprises corporate executives, property developers, and entrepreneurs in their late 30s and 40s. We lack the fine motor dexterity required for MOBAs. What we possess is disposable capital. In an SLG, capital translates directly into march speed, troop tiers, and geopolitical territory."
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> "The system operates on feudal economics. When I purchase an RMB 648 resource pack, all two hundred alliance members receive a bonus gift chest. Free-to-play participants supply defensive garrison numbers and scouting labor; paying leaders provide nuclear deterrent power and economic subsidies. It is an executive management simulator played on a smartphone screen."

3.8 Interview 8: Chinese Independent Developer

Participant: P-08 (Male, 31, Lead Designer, Independent Studio, Shanghai)
Thematic Focus: NPPA ISBN regulatory bottlenecks, Steam Global lifelines, and production limits.

> "Securing an official NPPA publishing license (ISBN /) represents the central operational hurdle for domestic studios. Review pipelines require exhaustive checks across narrative themes, historical representation, and minor protection systems. For a five-person team with twelve months of financial runway, waiting eighteen months for a license cycle is existentially fatal."
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> "Consequently, Chinese indie developers rely on Steam Global as an offshore lifeline. Because Steam operates internationally without requiring a localized ISBN, domestic PC players purchase our titles in RMB via cross-border payment gateways. Over 75% of our audience resides domestically, yet our revenue pipeline clears through international rails."
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> "Venture capital has largely abandoned non-live-service domestic indie games. We survive through personal savings, niche publishing advances, and extreme asset discipline. We deploy generative AI strictly for rapid pre-production concept art and script translation, reducing asset authoring timelines by 40%. But AI cannot balance a combat loop."

3.9 Interview 9: Game Engine & Systems Specialist

Participant: P-09 (Male, 36, Technical Director, Simulation Lab, Abu Dhabi Context)
Thematic Focus: Physical-vs-consumer hardware inversion, WebAssembly, and cross-platform architecture.

> "In the 1990s, custom arcade boards possessed specialized graphics silicon that consumer hardware could not match. Today, that relationship is completely inverted.

Modern arcade cabinets are standard mid-range x86 Windows motherboards housed inside bespoke metal chassis with custom I/O boards converting controls. The defensible moat of physical arcades is no longer computational horsepower; it is physical human-interface hardware: high-speed infrared touchscreens on *maimai*, pneumatic force-feedback steering wheels, and mechanical coin chutes."

"For web-based research prototypes, the combination of WebAssembly (Wasm) and WebGPU allows developers to run complex compiled C++/Rust logic in-browser at near-native execution speed. It circumvents the severe distribution friction of platform app stores and installation packages."

"The greatest engineering tax on modern studios like HoYoverse is cross-platform parity. You must author graphics pipelines capable of driving high-end desktop GPUs while maintaining asset streaming architectures that degrade gracefully on thermally constrained mobile chipsets."

3.10 Interview 10: Arcade Operations Supervisor

Participant: P-10 (Male, 46, Senior Floor Technician, Shanghai)
Thematic Focus: Machine economics, claw voltage calibration, and the acoustic power of coins.

"The operational heart of the venue is the claw machine and the coin pusher. Traditional video cabinets generate exceptionally low revenue per square meter—a master player occupies a *Street Fighter* cabinet for an hour on three tokens. We retain classic cabinets primarily as environmental dressing to establish an authentic arcade aura."

"Claw machines run on precise mathematical payout parameters configured on the motherboard. The technician sets the target payout ratio (e.g., 1-in-15 or 1-in-20 attempts). The claw maintains strong electromagnetic grip at the floor, lifts the plush, and then cuts voltage by 50% at the top of the stroke, dropping the toy. Only when the token threshold is satisfied does the machine maintain holding voltage to the chute."

"Digital Mini-Program scanning has reduced manual coin-clearing labor and cut physical theft. However, you sacrifice acoustic marketing. The physical sound of fifty brass tokens clattering into a metal coin tray causes the entire floor to turn their heads. It is an irreproducible sensory trigger that advertises that winning is occurring right now."

4 Qualitative Coding Framework & Thematic Findings

4.1 Master Qualitative Codebook

4.2 Exemplar Coded Memo

Raw Excerpt (Participant P-07): "In an SLG, your capital translates directly into military dominance, resource control, and alliance protection `[COMP: Capitalized Mastery] [SPND: Direct Capital Outlay]`. When our alliance wins the Sunfire Castle, I am King of the entire server. I appoint ministers, dictate tax rates, and grant titles `[PROG: Socio-Political Rank] [VALU: Psychological Spend Fulfillment]`. It is an executive management simulation played on a smartphone screen `[PLAT: Asynchronous Mobile Structure]`."

Analytical Memo: The participant demonstrates the conversion of real-world financial liquidity into virtual sociopolitical authority, substituting twitch mechanical execution with balance-sheet deployment.

Code	Node Label	Grounded Definition & Contextual Identifiers
DISC	Discovery Pipeline	Viral algorithms (Douyin/Bilibili), WeChat peer loops, offline mall foot-traffic.
ONBD	Onboarding Friction	Mechanical vs. digital learning curve; cognitive friction of rules and controls.
COMP	Competitive Mastery	Twitch motor skills, ladder anxiety, frame data optimization, competitive hierarchy.
SOCI	Social Embeddedness	WeChat graph lock-in, clan obligations, intergenerational bonding, physical dating.
EXPL	Spatial Exploration	Open-world traversal, environment curiosity, uncovering hidden game mechanics.
ATTA	Narrative & IP Attachment	Parasocial character devotion (*Chú lì*), aesthetic loyalty, transmedia consumption.
PROG	Progression Loops	Quantitative stat accumulation, gear refinement, account leveling, territory control.
SPND	Direct Capital Outlay	Token acquisition, gacha pulls, monthly subscriptions, VIP resource packs.
VALU	Perceived Utility	Subjective assessment of expenditure value (temporal duration vs. status return).
RETN	Retention Hooks	Daily commission chores, stamina gates, alliance war schedules, habituated play.
FRIC	Structural Obstacles	Regulatory ISBN delays, mechanical coin jams, gacha 50/50 losses, physical fatigue.
MONA	Monetization Literacy	Player awareness of commercial design (e.g., claw voltage tricks, fake ads, pity traps).
COMM	External Infrastructure	Steam Global, NetEase Cangbaoge asset trading, Bilibili strategy walkthroughs.
PLAT	Platform Specificity	Form-factor constraints: mobile touchscreens vs. CRT cabinets vs. WebAssembly.

Table 3: Systemic Qualitative Coding Dictionary

4.3 Cross-Cutting Thematic Synthesis

1. **Capital Velocity vs. Temporal Elasticity (Addressing Research Question 3):** Expenditure models in physical entertainment environments bifurcate into rapid-burn, high-velocity transactions (claw machines running at RMB 100 per 15 minutes) and temporally elastic activities (marble pushers providing 45 minutes of sustained mechanical play for RMB 19.50). This mirrors the digital landscape, which balances high-margin whale monetization (RMB 648 resource packs in SLGs) with low-friction, recurring daily subscriptions (RMB 30 monthly Welkin cards in open-world RPGs).

2. **Bifurcation of Contemporary Gaming Sociality (Addressing Research Question 2):** Social play in China has diverged across structural lines. Macro-digital sociality is dominated by ubiquitous platform graphs (Tencent's WeChat/QQ infrastructure in *Honor of Kings*), transforming the game into civic and corporate social currency. Conversely, physical arcade spaces preserve micro-subcultural sociality, sustained either through tacit, unspoken mutual presence (Street Jiliehuo's fighting game community) or collective physical observation (Fengyun Zaiqi's dance stages).

3. **Structural Insulation & Regulatory Navigation (Addressing Research Question 1):** Commercial game development models are fundamentally shaped by institutional constraints, notably the NPPA publishing license (ISBN /) pipeline. Commercial entities navigate these barriers through live-service retention architectures, while independent developers rely on cross-border offshore avenues (Steam Global). Simultaneously, physical arcades insulate themselves from consumer hardware parity by pivoting away from raw compute toward custom, un-emulatable physical human interfaces and redemption-driven carnival mechanics.

5 Mini-Game Grounding & Design Specifications

The three interactive browser games deployed within the virtual arcade project translate the qualitative and systemic findings into playable software models:

5.1 Mini-Game 1: Battle Arena (MOBA Archetype)

- **Commercial Reference:** *Honor of Kings* (, Tencent).
- **Qualitative Basis:** Translates findings from P-01 and P-05 regarding mechanical execution, animation cancel windows, competitive tension, and visual hierarchy.
- **Mechanics & Implementation:**
  - *Input Architecture:* WASD directional movement; `Spacebar` (Basic Attack); `J` (Special Ability on a 4-second cooldown).
  - *Animation Cancelling:* Triggering `J` immediately cancels the recovery frames of the basic attack, rewarding mechanical dexterity.
  - *Laning & Aggro Dynamics:* Minion waves march along a linear path. Attacking an enemy hero within range of the defensive turret redirects turret aggro onto the player, demonstrating systemic priority mechanics.
  - *Visual Reward Loops:* Gold numerical text indicators erupt upon last-hitting minions, simulating the micro-reward feedback loops characteristic of mobile MOBAs.

5.2 Mini-Game 2: Journey of the Lost Realm (Action RPG Archetype)

- **Commercial Reference:** *Genshin Impact* (HoYoverse) and *Fantasy Westward Journey* (NetEase).

- **Qualitative Basis:** Translates findings from P-06 regarding narrative gating, environmental relic collection, stamina pacing, and character-driven exploration.
- **Mechanics & Implementation:**
  - *Input Architecture:* WASD movement; `E` (Contextual NPC Interaction); `Spacebar` (Melee Attack).
  - *Gated Progression:* The central domain guardian is invulnerable until the player explores the environment to collect three hidden elemental relic fragments.
  - *Stamina Economy:* Sprinting and combat evasions draw down a dynamic stamina meter, illustrating real-time mechanical pacing constraints.
  - *Dialogue State Machines:* NPC dialogue branches adjust dynamically based on inventory flags, demonstrating persistent narrative progression.

5.3 Mini-Game 3: Frontier Settlement (Strategy/SLG Archetype)

- **Commercial Reference:** *Whiteout Survival* (, Century Games).
- **Qualitative Basis:** Translates findings from P-07 regarding asynchronous resource collection, survival anxiety, and the psychological relief of acceleration mechanics.
- **Mechanics & Implementation:**
  - *Input Architecture:* Primary mouse pointer click controls for resource management and building upgrades.
  - *Resource Triad:* Continuous tracking of Wood, Food, and Stone. Resource accumulation occurs across fixed real-time ticks.
  - *Survival Wave Timer:* A countdown timer signals incoming environmental blizzards. Insufficient food stores trigger an automatic 50% worker efficiency debuff, creating resource anxiety.
  - *Interactive Speed-Up:* Players can click an optional time-accelerator button, illustrating the psychological relief and dopamine trigger behind consumable monetization speed-ups in commercial 4X titles.

6 Synthesis: Mapping Industry Findings to Game Design

Research Layer	MOBA (Battle Arena)	RPG (Lost Realm)	SLG (Frontier)
Industry Dynamic	Domestic market saturation; dominant revenue via cosmetics.	Massive production budgets; high global cross-platform revenue.	Dominant overseas revenue driver; heavy performance marketing.
Core Player Motivation	Competitive ranking; social connection via WeChat graph.	Parasocial character love (*Chú lì*); narrative immersion.	Sociopolitical power; corporate alliance hierarchy.
Monetization Model	Fair competitive access; cosmetics & prestige items.	Gacha character banners; monthly battle passes.	Feudal resource packs; construction speed-ups.
Mini-Game Translation	Animation-cancelling combat; turret aggro priority.	Three-relic exploration gate; stamina meter constraints.	Resource generation ticks; survival countdown timer.

Table 4: Systemic Triangulation: Industry Research, Fieldwork, and Game Mechanics